



Diamonds in the Earth

A study by MIT shows that there may be as much as 10^{16} tonnes of diamonds hidden deep within the Earth. <https://digit.in/Aug18-64-1>



The Meghalayan Age

A rock recovered from Meghalaya has lent the name of the state to a newly named geological age. <https://digit.in/Aug18-64-2>



Credit: Aditya Laghate

NATURAL WONDERS OF INDIA

From unique crater lakes in basaltic rocks, to mysterious “ghost lights” without an established scientific explanation, there are many natural wonders to be witnessed in India.

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LONAR CRATER

The Lonar lake in the Buldhana district of Maharashtra was formed from a meteorite impact around 52,000 years ago. The crater is about 1.8 kilometres in diameter, and 150 metres deep. It is the only hypervelocity impact crater lake in basaltic rock anywhere in the world. The lake exhibits some unusual properties. The waters are both alkaline and saline, in layers that do not mix. Each of the layers support different species of

life forms. There are microorganisms found in the lake, including nitrogen fixing bacteria, that are rarely found elsewhere in the world. The lake is fed by a freshwater stream that originates from a temple. Most mysteriously, compasses fail to work at some points in the lake. There are various kinds of salts that are found in the lake, and are sold in the local markets. The salts vary in chemical characteristics, composition and appearance. The salts seem to originate from a source deep within the lake bed. It is unknown what is there at the bottom of the lake, and if the original meteorite is still there. The meteorite that caused the

impact is believed to weigh around 2 million tonnes, and was travelling at a speed of 90,000 kilometres per hour. The lake has been studied extensively, including by the Physical Research Laboratory (PRL), the Geological Society of India and the Smithsonian Institution.

BORRA CAVES

Located in the Visakhapatnam district in Andhra Pradesh, the Borra Caves are the deepest caves in India. They extend to a depth of 80 metres. The caves have various kinds of formations caused by mineral deposits over the years. There are many irregular stalactites and stalagmites, some of which are artificially lit for the pleasure of the tourists. The caves are so deep, that natural light never reaches the formations. Inside the cave, there is an ancient Shiva temple, where stalagmite are worshipped as the deity. The caves have been formed over a period of many years because of the water flowing in the Gosthani River. The water from the roof of the caves seeps through the limestone, and then drops to the floor. Tiny deposits left by these drops over the years has led to some interesting formations. These formations have been given names,